

Psalms 46

God Is Our Refuge

God is our refuge and strength
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble.*
- 2 *Therefore will not we fear, though the earth be removed, and though the mountains be carried into the midst of the sea;*
- 3 *Though the waters thereof roar and be troubled, though the mountains shake with the swelling thereof. Selah.*
- 4 *There is a river, the streams whereof shall make glad the city of God, the holy place of the tabernacles of the most High.*
- 5 *God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved: God shall help her, and that right early.*
- 6 *The heathen raged, the kingdoms were moved: he uttered his voice, the earth melted.*
- 7 *The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge. Selah.*
- 8 *Come, behold the works of the LORD, what desolations he hath made in the earth.*
- 9 *He maketh wars to cease unto the end of the earth; he breaketh the bow, and cutteth the spear in sunder; he burneth the chariot in the fire.*
- 10 *Be still, and know that I am God: I will be exalted among the heathen, I will be exalted in the earth.*
- 11 *The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge. Selah.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 46 is a confident hymn—the inspiration behind Luther’s “A Mighty Fortress Is Our God”—declaring God as refuge amid cosmic upheaval: earth removed, mountains cast into the sea, waters roaring. Against that chaos it sets the calm image of a river gladdening the city of God, and celebrates God’s decisive power to make wars cease across the earth. Its repeated refrain, “The Lord of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge,” anchors trust regardless of how threatening circumstances appear.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble; therefore we will not fear though the earth is removed, mountains cast into the midst of the sea, and its waters roar and be troubled.

Verse 4-7

A river’s streams make glad the city of God, the holy place of the tabernacles of the Most High; God is in her midst, so she shall not be moved—He will help her at the dawning of the morning. Nations raged and kingdoms were moved, but He uttered His voice and the earth melted; the refrain follows: “The Lord of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge.”

Verse 8-11

Come, behold the works of the Lord, the desolations He has made in the earth; He makes wars cease to the ends of the earth, breaking the bow, cutting the spear, burning the chariot. “Be still, and know that I am God: I will be exalted among the heathen, I will be exalted in the earth.” The refrain returns to close the psalm.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God’s presence as refuge does not depend on stability in the world around us; it holds even if the very foundations of creation were to give way. His sovereignty extends over nations and warfare itself, and stillness before Him is the fitting response to both cosmic chaos and geopolitical upheaval.

Application for life today.

When news or personal circumstances feel like “the earth removed” and “mountains cast into the sea,” return deliberately to this psalm’s refrain as an anchor. Practice “be still, and know that I am God” (v. 10) as an actual discipline—stopping striving or scrolling long enough to remember who is exalted over the nations. Look for the “river” of God’s presence (v. 4) that brings calm gladness even while surrounding waters roar.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What current “roaring waters” situation in your life or the world tempts you toward fear rather than the refuge this psalm describes?

2. What would it practically mean this week to “be still, and know that I am God” (v. 10) instead of anxious striving?

3. How does picturing God’s river of gladness in the midst of the city (v. 4) reshape how you approach a turbulent season?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).